

After years away in a vastly different environment (e.g., another country, a different social circle), a character returns to their hometown or original community, only to find they no longer fit in, nor do they fully belong where they've been. How will they navigate this liminal space?

Note: The following story takes place in Karachi and Brooklyn during the 1990s.

بھول نہ پاؤں گی کبھی، رہ گئے جو باتیں انکھی

"I'll never forget the words that were left unsaid" ~Kaavish, "Baat Unkahi"

It was a cold night in Brooklyn. His daughter climbed into his lap, and asked a seemingly innocent question: "Dad, where did you come from?" - not where I lived, but where I belonged, and honestly? I didn't know what to tell her. It had been so long since he'd really thought about it. Karachi? Maybe. Once.

"It's a place far away, my dear." And as he puts her to sleep, and microwaves his lukewarm coffee, he recounts his memories. The days of his intermediate studies, locked in his room, with his mother coming by and giving him a kiss along with a cup of chai and his father coming home with the newspaper, giddy, with the merit list - he had gotten the highest mark in the city.

He didn't plan to leave Karachi forever.

But after topping the board, the scholarship letter came. NYU - Full tuition. His mother cried tears of joy when she hugged him at the airport. His father's eyes were glittery, proud of his son's achievement, even though he didn't say much, it was all in his eyes, he was damn proud of him.

At the time, it felt like a beginning.

He'd told himself he would eventually return - after four years, after his degree, after making something of himself. But in life, things don't always go the way we plan. Four years became five. A masters turned into a job. Then came the apartment, his wife, the baby. His parents had passed during those years - quietly, suddenly. One after the other, he hadn't been there to hold their hands. Life moved forward. Karachi? It stood where it was.

Maybe it was the guilt that haunted him, the longing. The way his daughter had looked at him when she asked - like she was reaching for something buried in him.

Maybe it was just time. He called the travel agency, asking for three round-trip tickets to Karachi from JFK in two weeks, and paid it with a money order.

He didn't tell anyone, just his wife. Work? Told them he's going out of the country for a trip.

The plane touched down just after midnight. The warm air pushed through as soon as the cabin door opened, releasing a familiar scent – dust, diesel, sweat. Karachi had always been loud, but tonight it was quiet. There was no one waiting at the gate. No welcome, no faces, just silence.

The hotel room reeked of lemon-scented cleaner. His daughter jumped on the bed like it was an adventure. His wife, staring at the stars from the balcony. His bags? Unpacked.

The next morning, he left early.

He asked the rickshaw driver to take him to the old colony – the one where he'd grown up. It looked smaller, quieter. Like a wave had passed it. He walked past the park where he'd once played cricket with his friends. The concrete pitch was cracked, the swings creaking with rust, and everything began coming back to him in his mind, when he and his friends used to sneak out to play, their parents worried, whose window will they break now.

A horn blared. That life – those streets, those friends – was gone.

Just a few streets down, was the masjid of his childhood. The same green chipped walls, with the calligraphy fading just like his memories. He stepped inside. The scent hit him hard – attar, damp stone, old rugs warmed by sunlight. He made his way to the wudu area. The taps were still stiff like in his childhood. He washed slowly, like his father had taught him.

His hands trembled.

He entered the prayer hall, it was empty.

He stood alone, faced the qiblah, and began to pray.

Somewhere between sujood and ruku, tears started to fall. Soft at first, then heavier. When he finally sat back, he whispered,

“Who am I?”

But the masjid was silent.....

The next day, he took his daughter with him.

She didn't ask where they were going. She just held his hand, as they walked through the narrow lanes, past fruit carts and aging walls.

The cemetery's gate was rusted, the path was narrow, remembered from an old friend's call about their passing.

His parents, side by side.

Two simple white headstones.

He stood in front, unsure what to say.

His daughter, looking at the faded names, asked,

“Do you ever wish you'd stayed?”

He replied, "I do. I just... I don't know why I did what I did."

She reached for his hand again,

"Maybe this is all that's left."

He didn't say more. Just stood there, holding her hand, wondering – Was this moment enough?